

FUNCTIONAL ANALYSIS OF THE 2008 SADDLEBACK PRESIDENTIAL FORUM

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Abstract: On August 16, 2008, Pastor Rick Warren invited Senator Barack Obama and Senator John McCain to appear in a televised forum at his Church, the Saddleback Church. Although the nominating conventions had not yet been held, both McCain and Obama had amassed enough delegates to assure them the nominations of their political parties. General election debates were held in 1960 and from 1976-2008 but the idea of a presidential forum broadcast from a church was a new concept. This paper applies the Functional Theory of Political Campaign Discourse to the text of this forum, analyzing functions, topics, and issues addressed here. The candidates relied more on acclaims (positive statements about self) than attacks on opponents; the incumbent party candidate (Senator McCain) acclaimed more and attacked less than the challenger (Senator Obama). The candidates stressed policy more than character (although unlike previous debates, the Democratic candidate here did not discuss policy more than the Republican). Finally, each candidate stressed the issues owned by his political party more.

The 2008 presidential campaign was unusual in several aspects. It was the first campaign to feature an African-American as a major party presidential nominee, Senator Barack Obama; the second to feature a woman as a major party vice presidential nominee. President Bush was at the end of his second term and could not run again; Vice

President Cheney decided not to run for president. So, this was the first time since 1952 that a current president or vice president was not a candidate for president. The primary campaign started earlier than ever, with the Iowa caucuses on January 3 and the New Hampshire primary on January 8 (of course, candidates were on the campaign trail well in advance of the caucuses and primaries). Nevertheless, the campaign dragged on for months with Obama winning the Democratic nod on June 4, 2008 (Senator John McCain accumulated enough delegates to secure the Republican nomination on March 4).

This campaign had many traditional elements (nominating conventions, TV spots, general election debates) but one of the new elements was the Saddleback Presidential Candidate Forum. After the two candidates had clinched their respective nominations, Pastor Rick Warren invited Obama and McCain to attend a forum at his church. Warren is the pastor of the Saddleback Church (Lake Forest, CA) and leader of the Purpose Driven Network of Churches. According to Sermon Central, Saddleback Church is the eighth largest church in America with an attendance of over 19,000 (2008). On Sunday, August 16, 2008, the Saddleback Forum was held at Warren's church and broadcast live on CNN. Pastor Warren asked questions of each candidate (separately) for an hour. The candidates were not together on stage during the questions and answers.

This event offered voters a chance to see the two presumptive major party nominees near the beginning of the general election campaign. This forum was different from traditional presidential debates in several ways: It was held in a church and hosted by a pastor; the candidates were not on stage at the same time and could not respond or react to one another, and the questions were not asked by journalists (Warren asked the questions). This was not the first time religion surfaced in the 2008 presidential campaign; Hillary Clinton, John Edwards, and Barack Obama participated in the "Sojourners Forum" on June 4, 2008 (organized by

Reverend Jim Wallis). Furthermore, unflattering revelations about Obama's pastor, the Reverend Jeremiah Wright, forced Obama to give a speech on race (*New York Times*, 2008). This paper reports a content analysis of the 2008 Presidential Saddleback Forum. It will be interesting to compare the results of this analysis with similar studies of more traditional presidential debates from past years.

Literature Review

Numerous books (see, e.g., Benoit & Wells, 1996; Bishop, Meadow, & Jackson-Beeck, 1978; Bitzer & Rueter, 1980; Carlin & McKinney, 1994; Coleman, 2000; Dailey, Hinck, & Hinck, 2007; Friedenberg, 1994, 1997; Hellweg, Pfau, & Brydon, 1992; Hinck, 1993; Jamieson & Birdsell, 1988; Kraus, 1962, 1977, 2000; Lanoue & Schrott, 1991; Schroeder, 2000; Swerdlow, 1984, 1987) and many articles (see, e.g., Loudon, 2008; Racine Group, 2002) investigate presidential debates. This study adopts the Functional approach to political campaign messages for three reasons. First, research on German presidential debates has confirmed that viewers react differently to acclaims and attacks (Reinemann & Maurer, 2005). Second, research on this theory indicates that campaign messages are related to election outcome (candidates who stress policy more, and character less, than opponents are significantly more likely to win elections (Benoit, 2003). Finally, research employing that theory had produced longitudinal data on general election debates which can provide a useful comparison point for new work. We also use Petrocik's theory of issue ownership (1996) in this study.

Research on historic presidential debates (1960, 1976-2004; see Benoit, 2007a for a summary) found that the candidates' statements in these debates were mostly positive (57%), with attacks comprising about one-third of the utterances (35%); occasionally the candidates defended themselves from attacks (8%). Incumbent party candidates tended to acclaim more (64% to 51%) and attack less (25%

to 44%) than challenger candidates. Incumbents, who were subjected to more attacks than challengers, produced more defenses (12% to 6%). Research has found significant correlations between the number of attacks directed toward a candidate and the number of defenses produced by that candidate (Benoit, 2007b). Most of the comments by the candidates in general election debates were about policy (75%) with much less of the talk devoted to questions of character (25%). Democrats tended to emphasize policy even more (77% to 72%) and character even less (23% to 28%) than Republicans (Benoit, 2007a). Historically, both Democrats and Republicans have a tendency to discuss issues owned by the Republican Party (reputations for ability to handle an issue). However, Democrats discuss Democratic issues more (35% to 22%) and Republican issues less (78% to 65%) in general election debates (Benoit, 2007a). Finally, candidates in general election debates discuss the issues on which they are advantaged more than the issues on which the other party is favored (Benoit, 2007a; Benoit & Hansen, 2004).

Theoretical Underpinning

Functional Theory

The Functional Theory of Political Campaign Discourse was developed by Benoit and his associates through a series of studies (see, e.g., Benoit, 2007a). Functional Theory stipulates that people vote for the candidate who appears *preferable* on the criteria that matter to each voter (Benoit, 2007a). Candidates can establish desirability in three ways. First, the candidate can offer acclaims or self-praise. The more benefits of or advantages of one candidate, the more likely that person will appear preferable to a voter. Second, candidates can attack or criticize their opponents; as costs or disadvantages of opponents become more salient, opposing candidates should appear less desirable to voters (of course, it is possible that

candidates who attack could experience a backlash from voters who generally dislike mudslinging). Finally, candidates who have been the recipient of an attack can defend against (refute) that attack. The fewer and less important the costs or disadvantages, the more likely that a candidate will appear preferable to opponents. These three options can be seen as roughly similar to cost-benefit analysis, providing information that can help persuade the voter to prefer one candidate (we do not claim that voters systematically quantify the impact of acclaims, attacks, or defenses or perform mathematical calculations to decide their vote choice; acclaims tend to increase one's benefits, attacks may increase an opponent's costs, and defenses can reduce one's costs). As noted earlier, a study of German presidential debates found that viewers react differently to acclaims and attacks (Reinemann & Maurer, 2005). However, it is important to keep in mind that all voters do not react in the same way to a given utterance: For example, Jarman (2005) found that those who watched the second general election presidential debate in 2004 evaluated the comments from the candidate representing their own party more favorably than viewers who affiliated with the opposing party.

The three functions (acclaims, attacks, and defenses) can be employed on two broad topics, policy (issues) or character (personality). Policy utterances are those which address governmental action or problems that are amenable to governmental action. Character comments are about the candidates as individuals (personality, leadership experience, and values). Of course, the perceived importance of these two general topics of discourse can vary from one voter to another.

Functional Theory (Benoit, 2007a) predicts that acclaims will be more common than attacks: Conceptually, acclaims have no drawbacks; however, there is some incentive to moderate attacks because many voters report that they dislike mudslinging (Merritt, 1984; Stewart, 1975).

Defenses are expected to be rare for three reasons: Most attacks occur where a candidate is weak, so responding to an attack will usually take the candidate off-message; one must identify an attack before one can refute it and doing so could inform or remind voters of a potential weakness; and defenses may create the undesirable impression that the candidate is reactive rather than proactive. Past research (Benoit, 2007a) has shown that defenses are more common in debates than other media.

H1. The candidates in the 2008 Saddleback Forum will use more acclaims than attacks and more attacks than defenses.

Historically, incumbent party candidates have acclaimed more (64% to 51%), and attacked less (25% to 44%), than challengers (Benoit, 2007a). Although in some years the incumbent may face widespread perceptions of problems (e.g., President Bush in 1992), the challenger may need to provide a reason (problems in the *status quo*) to unseat the incumbent. Of course, 2008 was a fairly unusual campaign in that neither candidate was the current president or vice president. Nevertheless, John McCain was the incumbent party candidate and Barack Obama the challenger, so we predict:

H2. In the 2008 Saddleback Forum, the incumbent party candidate will acclaim more and attack less than the challenger candidate.

As noted above, research on previous general election presidential debates has found that policy is more common than character (Benoit, 2007a). Public opinion polls for presidential elections in America reveal that most voters say that policy is a more important influence on their vote than character (Benoit, 2003). Candidates have an important incentive to adapt their messages to voter desires, so Functional Theory predicts that policy will receive a heavier emphasis than character:

H3. The candidates in the 2008 Saddleback Forum will discuss policy more than character.

As just noted, presidential candidates in general election campaigns tend to stress policy more than character. However, Functional Theory (Benoit, 2007a) observes that in general Democrats are more likely to emphasize policy than Republicans, whereas Republicans discuss character more than Democrats. Democrats have a proclivity to see governmental solutions to problems whereas Republicans often prefer private action (e.g., charity). This means Democrats are more likely to discuss policy than Republicans. Research on presidential campaign messages (Benoit, 2004) confirms this expectation. Hence we predict:

H4. In the 2008 Saddleback Forum, the Democratic candidate will discuss policy more, and character less, than the Republican candidate.

Issue Ownership

One additional prediction, derived from issue ownership theory (Petrocik, 1996) will be investigated in this study. Over time, each of the two major political parties in the U.S. has become associated with different issues: More voters think one party can better deal with a given issue than the other party. For example, people tend to believe that Democrats can do a better job handling such issues as education and the environment; citizens are prone to think that Republicans can do a better job handling such issues as taxes and crime. Petrocik (1996) predicts that presidential candidates are likely to discuss the issues owned by their own political party more often than candidates from the other party. Research has supported this prediction in presidential nomination acceptance addresses and general television spots (Petrocik, Hansen, & Benoit, 2003/2004) as well as in presidential primary and general election debates (Benoit & Hansen, 2004). This study will investigate this prediction in the 2008 presidential primary debates:

H5. In the 2008 Saddleback Forum, the Democratic candidate will discuss Democratic

**issues more, and Republican issues less, than the
Republican candidate.**

These five hypotheses will guide our analysis of the 2008 Saddleback Forum.

Method

Our content analysis, following previous research using the Functional approach (Benoit, 2007a), employed four steps. The texts of the Saddleback Forum (obtained via Lexis-Nexis) were unitized into themes, or utterances that address a coherent idea (only candidate remarks were coded, although questions were part of the context unit used to interpret the candidates' utterances). Benoit (2000) described the theme as "the smallest unit of discourse that is capable of expressing a complete idea" (p. 280). Similarly, Berelson (1952) indicated that a theme is "an assertion about a subject" (p. 18). Holsti (1969) defines a theme as "a single assertion about some subject" (p. 116). Themes vary in length from a short phrase to several sentences: The textual excerpt must focus on a single idea to qualify as a theme.

Second, each theme's function was classified using the following rules:

- *Acclaims* portray the candidate speaking favorably.
- *Attacks* portray opponents unfavorably.
- *Defenses* respond to a prior attack on the candidate who is speaking.

Almost all in the remarks in the debates in our sample served one of these functions; the very few other (non-functional) utterances that occurred were not analyzed.

Third, the topic of each theme was classified according to these rules:

- *Policy* remarks concern governmental action and problems amenable to such action.
- *Character* remarks address properties, abilities, or attributes of the candidates.

Because defenses occur infrequently they were not coded by topic (policy or character).

Finally, each policy theme was examined to see if it concerned one of the five Democratic or Republican issues employed in the Issue Ownership analysis. Lexis-Nexis polls from the Roper Center in 2007 were employed to select the issues employed to test the last hypothesis on issue ownership. Initially, Iraq, the economy/jobs, health care, education, and the environment were chosen as issues owned by the Democratic Party; immigration, terrorism, abortion, taxes, and crime were selected as Republican issues.

To illustrate how these texts were coded (and to clarify the nature of our coding categories) we offer examples of the three functions and two topics from the texts in our sample. For instance, in this passage, Obama criticized the status quo: “I believe it is irresponsible inter-generationally for us to invest or for us to spend \$10 billion a month on a war and not have a way of paying for it.” Whether one supports the war in Iraq or not, surely most people would agree we should not spend these huge sums without having a way to pay for it, so this excerpt was coded as an attack. It negatively assesses policy generally (governmental action) and the war in Iraq in particular, so this excerpt was coded as an attack.

We employed Cohen’s κ for calculating inter-coder reliability because this statistic controls for agreement by chance. Reliability was calculated on about 10% of the texts. The κ s were .92 for functions, .86 for topics, .96 for issue addressed. Landis and Koch (1977) indicate that these levels of agreement are acceptable: κ s of .81 and above reflect “almost perfect” agreement (p. 165), so these data should be considered reliable.

Results

The first hypothesis concerned the allocation of the three functions in this forum. Acclaims were much more common than attacks (80% to 20%); no defenses occurred in these messages. For example, McCain offered two acclaims in this utterance: “If I’m president of the United States, my

friends, if I have to follow him to the gates of hell, I will get Bin Laden and bring him to justice. I will do that. And I know how to do that. I will get that done.” Americans would agree with this policy goal (bringing Bin Laden to justice) and having a president who knows how to do this (leadership ability) would be desirable, so these two themes function as acclaims. Obama provided an example of an attack when he criticized President Bush on abortion: “The fact is that although we have had a president who is opposed to abortion over the last eight years, abortions have not gone down.” Even those who are pro-life can oppose abortion (preferring adoption, for example), so the fact that the number of abortions has not gone down is an attack. A chi-square goodness of fit test confirms that the frequency of acclaims was significantly different from the frequency of attacks ($\chi^2 [1, 194] = 69.36, p < .0001$). So, these data confirm the first hypothesis (see Table 1).

Table 1. Functions of 2008 Saddleback Forum

	Acclaims	Attacks	Defenses
Obama	84 (72%)	32 (28%)	0
McCain	71 (91%)	7 (9%)	0
Total 2008	155 (80%)	39 (20%)	0
Past Debates	4050 (57%)	2501 (35%)	604 (8%)

H2 anticipated that the incumbent party candidate, Senator John McCain, would acclaim more and attack less than the challenger, Senator Barack Obama. This prediction was confirmed in this Forum. Although both candidates acclaimed more than they attacked, McCain acclaimed more (91% to 72%) and attacked less (9% to 28%) than Obama. Statistical analysis confirms that these differences are significant ($\chi^2 [1, 194] = 10.06, p < .005, \phi = .23$). These data are also displayed in Table 1.

The third prediction addressed the topic of discourse in this Forum. As predicted, the two candidates focused

more on policy (84%) than character (16%). Discussion of the war in Iraq, mentioned above, illustrates a policy topic. John McCain's declaration about his leadership ability ("I know how to do that [bring Bin Laden to justice]") illustrates an utterance about character. This difference was significant ($\chi^2 [1, 194] = 94.32, p < .0001$). See Table 2 for these data.

Table 2. Topics of 2008 Saddleback Forum

	Policy	Character
Obama	98 (84%)	18 (16%)
McCain	65 (83%)	13 (17%)
Total 2008	163 (84%)	31 (16%)
Past Debates	4885 (75%)	1666 (25%)

The next hypothesis expected that the Democratic candidate would discuss policy more, and character less, than the Republican candidate. Both candidates stressed policy to about the same degree (Obama 84%, McCain 83%). These differences were not significant ($\chi^2 [1, 194] = 0.05, p > .8$). See Table 2 for these data. The power of this test to detect small, medium, and large differences is .27, .98, and greater than .99, respectively (Cohen, 1988).

The final prediction concerned Issue Ownership Theory (Petrocik, 1996), anticipating that the Democratic candidate would emphasize Democratic issues more, and Republican issues less, than the Republican. As expected, in this Forum Obama's utterances focused more on Democratic issues than Republican ones (67% to 33%) whereas McCain discussed Republican issues more than Democratic issues (58% to 42%). Statistical analysis confirms that these differences are significant ($\chi^2 [1, 91] = 5.82, p < .05, \phi = .25$). See Table 3.

Table 3. Issue Ownership in 2008 Saddleback Forum

	Democratic	Republican
Obama	31 (67%)	15 (33%)
McCain	19 (42%)	26 (58%)
Past Democrats	1916 (35%)	3595 (65%)
Past Republicans	896 (22%)	3103 (78%)

Discussion

This campaign event resembled previous general election debates in several ways. Acclaims were more common than attacks; defenses were the least common function (defenses were not used in this Forum). However, the discourse in this Forum was more positive than in previous debates (80% acclaims here, 57% in previous general election debates; 20% attacks here, 35% attacks in earlier debates). The absence of defenses may reflect the fact that fewer attacks are likely to provoke fewer (or no) defenses (Benoit, 2007b). A chi-square confirms that these differences are significant ($\chi^2 [1, 6745] = 26.08, p < .0001, \phi = .06$). It is possible that the format of this event, in which the two candidates were not on stage together (reducing direct confrontation), played a role here. Furthermore, previous research has shown that defenses are related to (prompted by) attacks (Benoit, 2007b); the infrequency of attacks may explain the lack of defenses here.

As in earlier general debates, this forum emphasized policy over character. However, these messages privileged policy even more than in previous years' general election debates: 84% policy here, 75% policy historically ($\chi^2 [1, 6745] = 8.94, p < .005, \phi = .04$). America's economic woes had begun before the Forum was held in August (Associated Press, 2008) and many were concerned about the war in Iraq, so perhaps it is not too surprising that policy dominated this forum. Perhaps the unusually high focus on policy (84%) left little room for distinctions between the two candidates (historically, Democrats focus even more on policy than Republicans).

Finally, as predicted by Issue Ownership Theory, the candidates focused more on the issues they owned than on the issues owned by the opposing party. If campaigns are viewed as a struggle to increase the salience of issues that favor each candidate, Obama and McCain were working to achieve an advantage on the issues their own party owned.

Conclusion

The Saddleback Forum in 2008 was a new development in presidential general election campaigns. Both candidates appeared and responded to questions, but they were not on stage simultaneously. This event has much in common with general election debates and those debates provide a context for investigating the Forum. In many ways, the forum resembled traditional debates: an emphasis on acclaims, policy, and on the issues owned by a candidate's political party; the challenger candidate also had more acclaims and fewer attacks than the incumbent party candidate (despite the fact that McCain, neither president nor vice president during the campaign, was not a "true" incumbent). However, some of these contrasts were heightened, as the forum was more positive and more focused on policy than general election debates. The relative lack of attacks (and the fact that the two candidates did not share the stage) may explain their failure to use any defenses. Perhaps because there was such an emphasis on policy (84%), the Democratic candidate had no greater emphasis on policy than the Republican.

All research has limitations and this study is no exception. It is important to acknowledge that Functional Theory does not address all aspects of discourse. For example, no attempt is made to analyze such concepts as metaphor, word choice, or evidence. Furthermore, this Forum was but one event in a campaign full of messages. Nor does this study attempt to see how media (or others) portrayed or commented on this Forum. One can question whether or not this event qualifies as a "debate" (although

one can argue that more traditional debates are not genuine; see Auer, 1962 or Jamieson & Birdsell, 1988). Still, this study investigates some aspects of a new general election event: a religious forum between the presumptive nominees of the two major political parties.

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